THE HARSH TRUTH FIRST

Before You Start, Know This:

- 70% of freelancers on Fiverr make less than $100 a month, and 96.3% make less than $500 a month

Reality of Success:

- Freelancers who land their first client within 30 days are 3x more likely to build sustainable income. Those who take longer than 90 days have a 67% dropout rate
- Most beginners wait 30-60 days with ZERO orders
- Your first month earnings will likely be LKR 10,000-25,000 (if you get clients)
- You'll work harder than a regular job initially

Platform Fees (They Take Your Money):

- Fiverr: **20% commission** on everything you earn
- Upwork: **20% first $500**, then **10%** up to $10,000, then **5%**
- If you earn LKR 10,000 :
    - You only get LKR 8,000 (Fiverr)
    - LKR 8,000-9,000 (Upwork)

HOW TO SETUP A GREAT GIG (FIVERR)

STEP 1: Choose RIGHT Niche (Most Important!)

Do This Specific:

✅ "I will design Instagram carousel posts for health coaches"

✅ "I will create YouTube thumbnails for gaming channels"

✅ "I will design menu cards for restaurants"

STEP 2: Write Killer Gig Title

Formula: "I will [specific action] + [for specific people] + [with specific result]"

Examples:

- ✅ "I will design 10 Insta posts for fitness brand with editable design"
- ✅ "I will create professional YouTube thumbnails that increase your clicks"
- ✅ "I will design a complete social media kit for small businesses"

STEP 3: Gig Description Must Answer:

👋 Hi! I'm [Name], a graphics designer with [X months/years] experience.

❓ WHAT YOU'LL GET:

• 10 custom Instagram posts

• Source files (PSD/AI)

• 2 revisions included

• Fast 24-hour delivery

✅ WHY CHOOSE ME:

• I understand [your niche] businesses

• Clean, modern designs

• Unlimited support after delivery

• [Any certifications or experience]

📝 WHAT I NEED FROM YOU:

• Your brand colors/logo

• Content/text for posts

• Any reference images you like

💬 Got questions? Message me before ordering!

Let's make your brand stand out! 🚀

STEP 4: Pricing Structure (CRITICAL)

Right Way (What Works):

Basic Package ($12-20 USD = LKR 3,800-6,500):

- 3 social media posts
- 1 revision
- 2-day delivery
- "Perfect for testing my work"

Standard Package ($35-45 USD = LKR 11,000-14,500):

- 10 social media posts
- 2 revisions
- 3-day delivery
- Source files included
- "Most popular - best value!"

Premium Package ($65-85 USD = LKR 21,000-27,000):

- 20 social media posts
- Unlimited revisions
- 1-day delivery
- Source files + templates
- Priority support
- "For serious brands"

STEP 5: Gig Image/Video (40% More Orders!)

Gig Image Must Have:

- ✅ Your best work sample
- ✅ Before/After comparison
- ✅ Text: "Instagram Posts Designer" or your service
- ✅ Bright colours
- ✅ Professional look

Professional gig video leads to 40% more orders

Gig Video Script (30 seconds):

Hi! I'm [Name].

I design [your service] for [your niche].

You'll get [main benefit] in [time frame].

My clients love [specific thing].

Click 'Continue' to get started!

HOW TO SETUP GREAT PROFILE (UPWORK)

STEP 1: Professional Photo

- ✅ Face clearly visible
- ✅ Smile
- ✅ Professional clothes
- ✅ Good lighting
- ✅ Plain background

A professional photo leads to 40% more views

STEP 2: Headline (Super Important)

Good Examples:

- ✅ "Instagram & Social Media Designer | 50+ Happy Clients"
- ✅ "YouTube Thumbnail Specialist - Boost Your CTR"
- ✅ "Brand Identity Designer for Startups & Small Business"

Formula: "[What you do] | [Who you help] | [Proof/Result]"

STEP 3: Overview (First 2 Lines Critical!)

Template:

I help [type of business] with [specific problem] using [your skill].

My last client [specific result - numbers if possible].

WHAT I OFFER:

• [Service 1]

• [Service 2]

WHY WORK WITH ME:

✓ Fast response (within 2 hours)

✓ Unlimited revisions until happy

✓ [X] years experience in [niche]

✓ Clear communication

I'm online 12 hours daily. Let's discuss your project!

STEP 4: Portfolio (Even With No Clients)

1. Create 3-5 sample projects
2. Make them for fake clients: "Social media posts for Fitness" (created it yourself)
3. Make them look REAL
4. Show different styles

STEP 5: Hourly Rate

For Sri Lankan Designers:

- Beginner (0-1 year): **$8-12/hour** (LKR 2,600-3,900/hour)
- Intermediate (1-2 years): **$12-18/hour** (LKR 3,900-5,850/hour)
- Advanced (2+ years): **$18-25/hour** (LKR 5,850-8,100/hour)

HOW TO GET FIRST 2 CLIENTS FAST (PROVEN METHODS)

FIVERR STRATEGY (7-14 Days to First Client)

Day 1-2: Setup

1. Create 3 gigs (different services or niches)
2. Complete profile 100%
3. Add professional photo
4. Create gig video for at least 1 gig

Day 3-14: Active Promotion

Buyer Requests (Most Important!):

- Check "Buyer Requests" section
- Send 10 offers EVERY DAY
- Personalize each offer (don't copy-paste)
- Example: "Hi [Name]! I saw you need Instagram posts. I specialize in [their niche]. I can deliver 10 professional posts in 2 days. Check my portfolio: [link]. Happy to discuss your vision!"

Be Online During Peak Hours:

- 9 AM - 12 PM (your time)
- 7 PM - 10 PM (your time)
- Green "online" status = more visibility

Share Gig on Social Media:

• Facebook groups for freelancers

• LinkedIn post

• Instagram story

• WhatsApp status

SECRET WEAPONS FOR FASTER SUCCESS:

1. Offer First Project Discount: "This is my first Upwork project, so I'm offering 20% discount to build my reviews. After this, my rate goes back to normal."

2. Offer Free Small Sample: "I can create 1 sample post for free so you can see my quality before committing."

3. Target New Clients: • On Upwork, filter for clients with 0-5 reviews • They're also new, less competitive • More likely to give you a chance

4. Apply Only to Jobs You Can CRUSH: Your first job isn't about money. It's about getting a 5-star review

5. Over-Deliver Like Crazy: • If they ask for 5 posts, give 6 • Deliver 1 day early • Include bonus: "I also created 3 Instagram story templates for you!" • Add instruction document

NEVER DO:

1. Never Accept Work Outside Platform: ❌ Client says "Let's work on WhatsApp and I'll pay you directly"

Why dangerous: No protection, they can disappear with your work, no reviews

2. Never Work Before Payment: ❌ "Send me the design first, then I'll order"

What to say: "Fiverr/Upwork policy requires payment first. Once you order, I start immediately!"

3. Never Argue About Revisions: ❌ "I already did what you asked!"

Better: "I understand. Let me adjust that for you. Can you show me an example of what you're looking for?"

4. Never Miss Deadlines: ❌ Delivering late without communication

Better: If running late, tell them 1 day BEFORE deadline: "I'm working on quality details. Need 6 extra hours. Is that okay?"

5. Never Use Downloaded/Stolen Resources: ❌ Using copyrighted images, fonts, templates without permission

Why: Client can get in legal trouble, you get banned

6. Never Over-Promise: ❌ "I'll make you viral!" or "Guaranteed 1000% engagement!"

Better: "I'll create professional, engaging designs that represent your brand well"

HOW TO HANDLE PRICING OBJECTIONS

Client: "This is too expensive"

"I understand! Let me explain what's included: [list deliverables]. I also provide unlimited support after delivery. Most designers charge $[higher amount] for this. Would the Standard package at $[amount] work better for your budget?"

Client: "Can you do it for $5?"

"I appreciate your budget constraints! At $5, I wouldn't be able to deliver the quality I'm known for. My minimum is $[amount] for [deliverable]. This ensures I can give your project proper attention and revisions."

Client: "I found someone cheaper"

"That's great you have options! Everyone has different pricing based on their experience and approach. My prices reflect [specific value - fast delivery/unlimited revisions/specialized experience in their niche]. If budget is the main factor, I understand. But if quality and support matter, I'd love to work with you. Decision is yours!"

FINAL HONEST WARNINGS

Things That Will Happen:

1. First month is HARD (mentally draining)
2. You'll get rejected a lot (normal)
3. Some clients will be difficult (learn from it)
4. Your first projects won't be profitable (building reputation)
5. You'll want to quit after 2 weeks (don't!)

Things That WON'T Happen:

1. ❌ Quick riches
2. ❌ Passive income in month 1
3. ❌ All 5-star reviews
4. ❌ Everyone accepting your prices
5. ❌ Easy success

MY PERSONAL ADVICE

After years on these platforms, here's what I wish someone told me:

1. **Your first client changes everything** - Before: anxiety. After: confidence.
2. **Cheap clients waste time** - One $50 client is better than five $5 clients
3. **Niche down** - "Social media designer" gets lost. "Instagram designer for real estate agents" gets noticed.
4. **Communication > Skills** - Average work + excellent communication beats excellent work + poor communication
5. **First 10 reviews are hardest** - After that, momentum builds naturally
6. **Don't quit your current job** immediately - Build freelance on the side first, switch when you're making 50% of your salary
7. **Weekends matter** - Many clients browse on weekends, be online